Systemic Racism in Canadian Healthcare: The Impact on Physicians and Patient Outcomes

Kola Adegoke, DrPH, CPHIMS, & Abimbola Adegoke BHS (Public Health), MSHI

Introduction

✅ **Systemic racism in Canadian healthcare disproportionately affects Black, Indigenous, and racialized communities.**
✅ **Despite Canada's universal healthcare model, racial disparities persist in patient care, physician representation, and policy structures.**
✅ **This study examines racial inequities, workforce barriers for internationally trained physicians (ITPs), and systemic policy gaps.**

Methodology

✅ **Research Design:** Literature review and policy analysis.
✅ **Data Sources:** Peer-reviewed studies, government reports, and physician testimonies.
✅ **Focus Areas:**
. **Discrimination Against Minority Physicians**
. **Impact on Patient Outcomes**
. **Policy Gaps and Reforms**

Public Health Implications

✅ **Physician Discrimination:** Racialized doctors face **workplace bias, limited career advancement, and inadequate institutional support.**
✅ **Healthcare Access:** Minority patients experience **longer wait times and lower-quality treatment** in certain healthcare settings.
✅ **Institutional Bias:** Existing policies **fail to protect healthcare professionals from discrimination and exclusion.**
✅ **Cultural Competency Training:** Training can help **reduce implicit bias and enhance patient care.**
✅ **Policy Reforms:** Strengthening **anti-discrimination laws** is essential for systemic change.

Future Direction

✅ **Longitudinal Studies**: Further research is needed to assess the long-term effects of discrimination on physician well-being and retention, affecting patient outcomes as 22% of Canadians lack access to care
✅ **Legal and Policy Advocacy**: Encouraging government action to enforce equity-driven healthcare reforms.
✅ **Intersectionality Research**: Examining the compounded effects of racism, gender bias, and socioeconomic status.

Findings

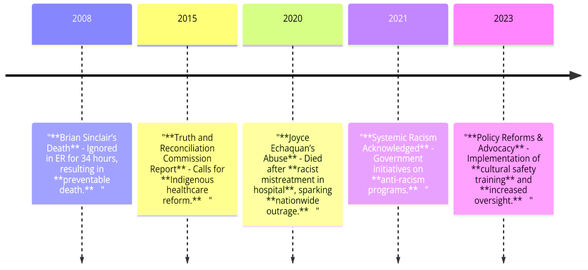


Figure 1: Timeline of Systemic Racism in Canadian Healthcare

(Key events from 2008–2023, highlighting major cases such as Brian Sinclair and Joyce Echaquan) .

Demographic Group	Disparity Example	Key Finding
Indigenous Patients	High rates of chronic illnesses such as diabetes and cardiovascular diseases	Need for targeted chronic disease prevention programs
Black Canadians	Higher maternal mortality rates compared to non-racialized groups	There is an urgent need for improved maternal healthcare and anti-racism training
Other Racialized Groups	Increased instances of misdiagnoses and delayed treatments	Requirement for equity in diagnostic procedures and timely care

Table 1: Identifies racial inequality in health status between Canada's largest groups of citizens. For example, Indigenous individuals have disproportionately high long-term disease, and Black Canadians have high maternal mortality. All such inequities require interventions at a systemic level **(29)**.

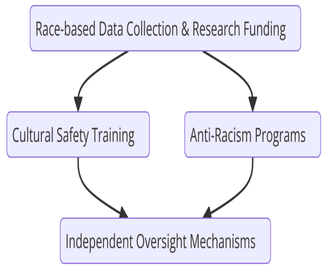


Figure 2: Roadmap to Equitable Healthcare Reform is represented in graphical form below

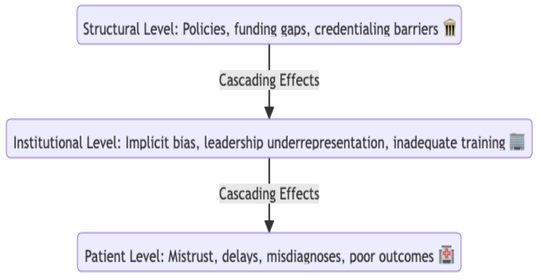
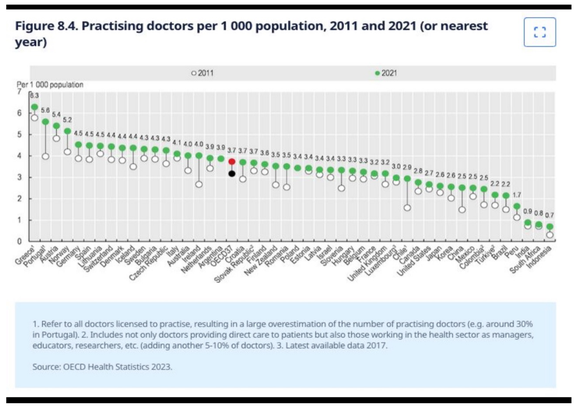


Figure 3: Here is the graph diagram illustrating **Systemic Racism in Canadian Healthcare**



Conclusion

Systemic racism in Canadian healthcare undermines the quality and fairness of medical practice. Addressing discrimination against physicians and patients is essential for an equitable, patient-centered healthcare system.

✅ **Improving access & quality of care for racialized communities**
✅ **Diversifying medical leadership & workforce equity**
✅ **Addressing physician shortages through ITP integration**
✅ **Strengthening policy enforcement to eliminate systemic racism**

References

1. Allan, B., & Smylie, J. (2015). First Peoples, second class treatment: The role of racism in the health and well-being of Indigenous Peoples in Canada. Wellesley Institute.
2. Boyer, Y. (2017). Healing racism in Canadian healthcare. Canadian Medical Association Journal, 189(46), E1408–E1409. https://doi.org/10.1503/cmaj.171234
3. Browne, A. J., Varcoe, C., Lavoie, J., et al. (2016). Enhancing healthcare equity with Indigenous populations. BMC Health Services Research, 16(544). https://doi.org/10.1186/s12913-016-1707-9
4. Public Health Agency of Canada. (2023). Inequalities in health of racialized adults in Canada. Government of Canada.
5. Phillips-Beck, W., Eni, R., Lavoie, J. G., et al. (2020). Confronting racism in Canadian healthcare: Systemic exclusion of First Nations. International Journal of Environmental Research and Public Health, 17(22), 8343. https://doi.org/10.3390/ijerph17228343
6. Williams, K. K. A., Baidoobonso, S., Lofters, A., et al. (2024). Anti-Black racism in Canadian healthcare: A qualitative study. BMC Public Health, 24(3152). https://doi.org/10.1186/s12889-024-20636-0

.

Link to the article